receive a call to say that Mr Gandhi would be pleased to have breakfast with me the next morning.

There was only one slight hitch—I was in Mumbai doing a live show on the city's civic elections when the call came. My appointment, I was told, was at 8 a.m. sharp. No early morning Mumbai–Delhi flight would get me back on time and I was too late to take the late-night flight. Thankfully, I discovered that there was an international flight at 2.30 a.m. which ferried hordes of migrant workers from Mumbai via Delhi and Lucknow to the Gulf. So, seated amidst a large crowd of sleepy, rather desperate-looking Indians heading out to make their future in the Saudi capital, I finally reached our national capital. A few hours' sleep and I was on my way to Rahul's office-cum-residence at 12, Tughlak Lane, bleary-eyed but hopeful that my long vigil for an interview was over.

On arrival, I realized I wasn't the only editor who had been summoned to the 'court' of Mr Gandhi. What I presumed was an interview was actually an informal press conference. Chai and idlis had been laid out and Mr Gandhi's man Friday Kanishka Singh was bustling around making sure every journalist was feeling comfortable. When Mr Gandhi arrived, he apologized for the last-minute invitation but mentioned he'd been awfully tied up crisscrossing UP. 'But I shall be happy to take all your questions,' was the earnest assurance.

Editors in a group can be terribly competitive and self-important. Each one of us was attempting to outdo the other by asking that one question which would be seen as truly 'newsy'. I asked two questions. The first was whether Rahul had ever considered putting himself up as the Congress's chief ministerial candidate for Uttar Pradesh. After all, Mayawati was the Bahujan Samaj Party's (BSP) incumbent chief minister, Akhilesh Yadav was the face of a potential SP government, why should anyone vote for the Congress when the party didn't even have a chief ministerial nominee? Even Jawaharlal Nehru had cut his teeth in Allahabad politics and had even been the city's mayor, so why didn't Rahul Gandhi offer himself to the UP voters as their man in the Lucknow hot seat? 'Good question,' said Mr